
Calculate the position, then use the pattern

PATTERNS ARE PROMPTS

A knight fork, a long diagonal or a pawn storm tells you where to look. It does not prove a combination works. Every lesson below points to a specific calculation or practical decision.

DEFENDING IS PART OF PLAYING AN ATTACKING OPENING

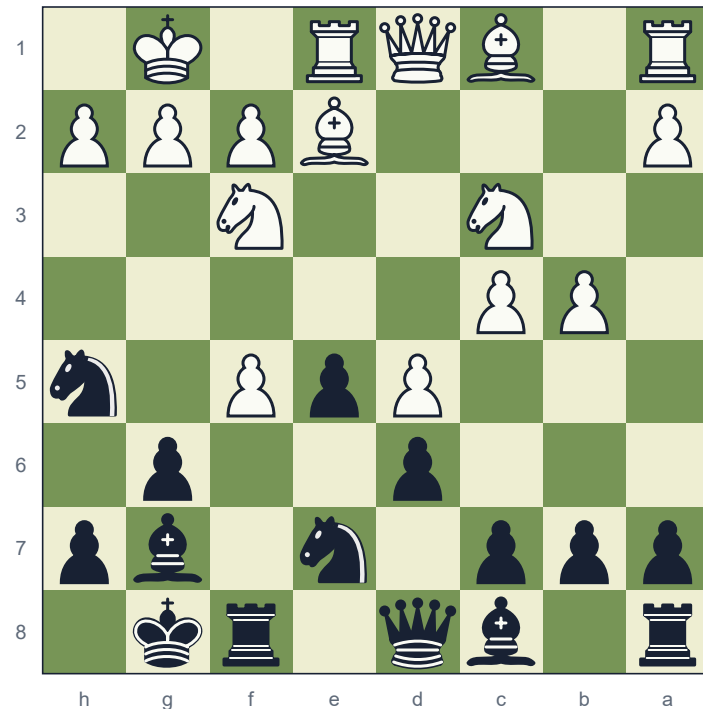
You must be able to stop a forcing threat, exchange queens when necessary and play a reduced-material position. Refusing every trade is as limiting as trading automatically.

HOW TO USE THE ENDGAME-TRANSITION PAGES

The diagrams show opening or middlegame starting points for decisions about simplification. They are not claimed to be theoretical endgame studies or forced winning positions. The task is to judge what a proposed exchange leaves behind.

The central intermediate move

TACTICAL DECISION | 04-03



Black to move

THE IDEA

After White captures on f5 in this exact Bayonet line, ...e4 attacks Nf3 while clearing the g7 bishop's diagonal toward Nc3. Looking only at recaptures misses the combined threat.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

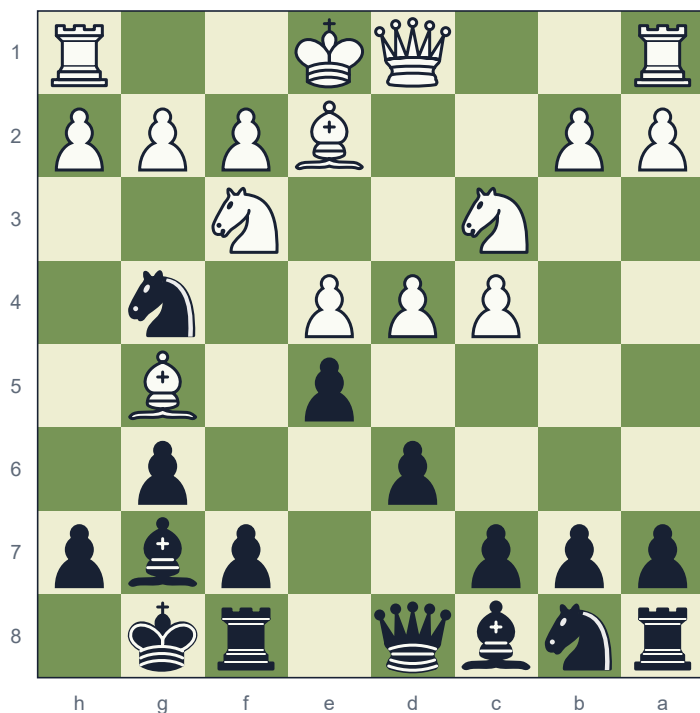
List White's knight moves and the effect of ...Bxc3. Check whether a recapture on f5 can wait. This is a concrete motif tied to the current piece placement, not a rule to push ...e4 after every exf5.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Before any automatic recapture, spend a moment looking for checks, stronger captures and attacks on two pieces.

Pins can decide a pawn break

TACTICAL DECISION | 08-01



Black to move

THE IDEA

Bg5 influences the diagonal toward the black queen. A knight move that seems natural can expose a queen or allow a central capture. ...f6 is a concrete way to interrupt that diagonal in this line.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

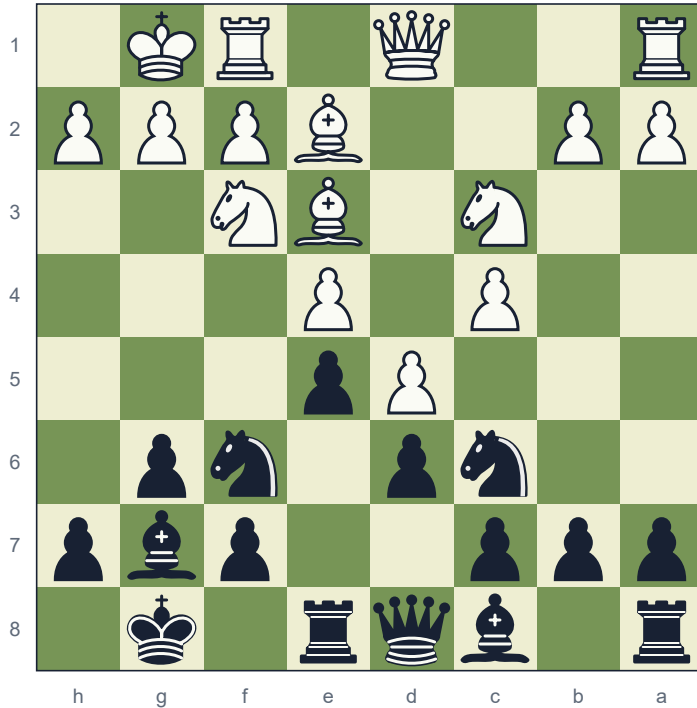
Trace the whole diagonal from the bishop to its target. A relative pin against a queen is different from an absolute pin against a king, but either can constrain your practical choices.

HABIT TO RETAIN

When you want ...f5 or a knight retreat, verify that the pinned piece can actually move without a tactical loss.

A forward retreat: ...Nd4

TACTICAL DECISION | 02-02



Black to move

THE IDEA

After ...Re8 and d5, the c6 knight need not always retreat to e7. Here ...Nd4 uses support from e5 and pressure on the e-file.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

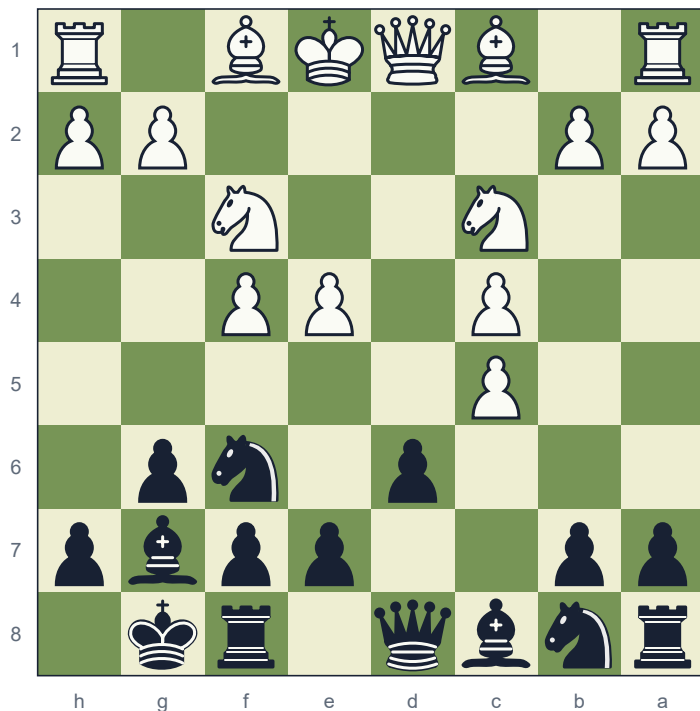
Calculate both Bxd4 and Nxd4, including the pawn recapture and the opening of the g7 bishop. A defended outpost is strongest when exchanges improve the rest of your pieces.

HABIT TO RETAIN

When a piece is attacked, search active squares as well as backward moves.

The queen attacks two central pawns

TACTICAL DECISION | 11-03



Black to move

THE IDEA

After dxc5 in the Four Pawns line, $\dots\text{Qa5}$ creates pressure on c5 and e4. The queen uses the diagonal that White's central capture helped expose.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

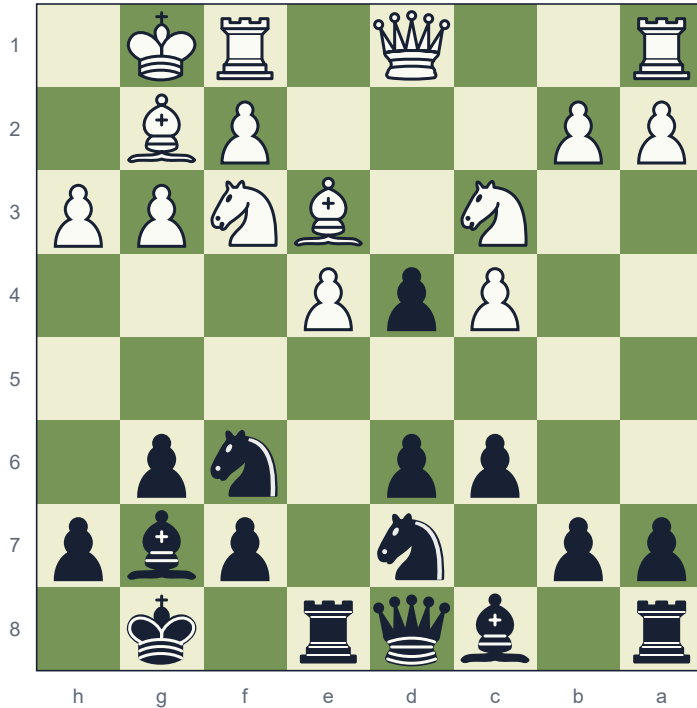
Do not stop the calculation at a double attack. Look for Bd2 , a queen exchange, or a move that develops while defending both targets. Then decide which pawn can be recovered safely.

HABIT TO RETAIN

A queen sortie should achieve something concrete and leave a safe route back.

The bishop on g7: defender and attacker

TACTICAL DECISION | 14-01



White to move

THE IDEA

The fianchetto bishop protects dark squares near the king and can attack through the center. A blocked diagonal does not make the bishop disposable.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

Before exchanging it for a knight, compare the remaining dark-square defenders, White's queen access and the pawn structure. In a concrete position the exchange may be excellent; the point is to know what protection you give up.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Name both the attacking diagonal and the defensive squares before trading the bishop.

Defending against Bh6

TACTICAL DECISION | 09-03



White to move

THE IDEA

White often uses Be3 and Qd2 to offer an exchange on h6. Removing Bg7 can weaken the dark squares and make h-pawn attacks more dangerous.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

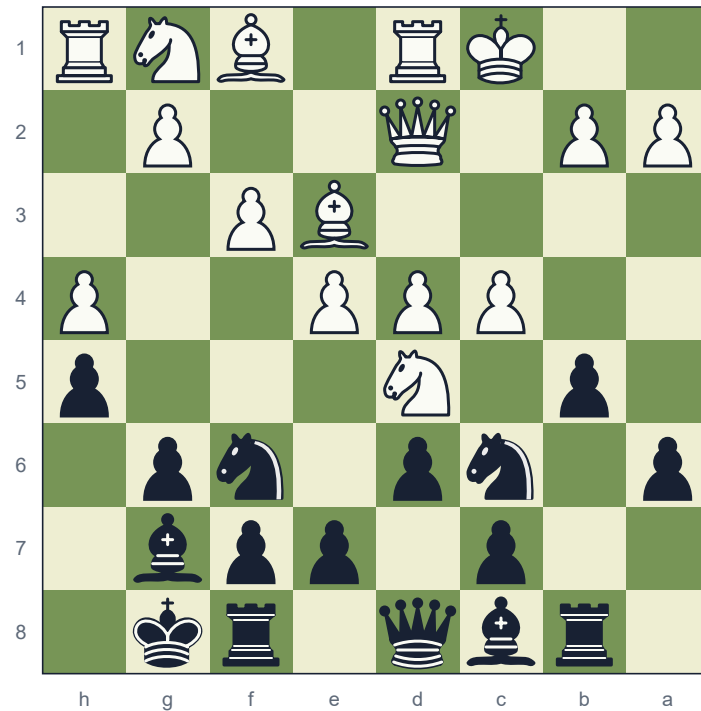
Compare allowing the exchange, moving the bishop, or creating a forcing counterthreat. Do not assume ...Bxh6 is compulsory. The center and queen placement decide whether a bishop trade is safe.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Answer the threat with a calculation, then restore active counterplay.

When not to capture a pawn near your king

TACTICAL DECISION | 10-04



White to move

THE IDEA

A pawn on h5 or g5 can be bait. Capturing it may open the h-file or a diagonal toward your king, especially when White has a rook ready on h1.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

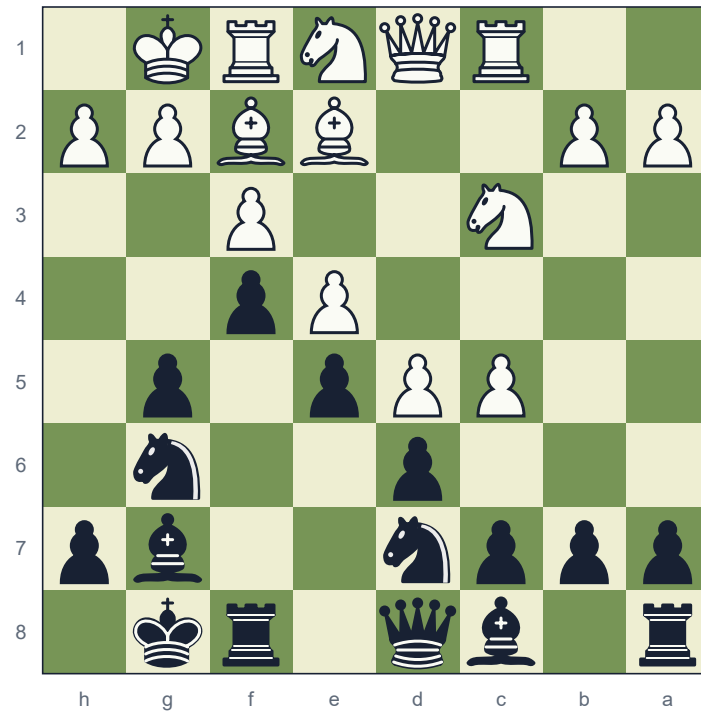
After each candidate capture, draw the newly opened file mentally and count attacking and defending pieces. Compare declining the pawn and striking in the center.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Material near the king is worth taking only if the resulting lines are safe.

Exchange sacrifices: a calculation standard

TACTICAL DECISION | 03-04



Black to move

THE IDEA

Closed KID positions can produce sacrifices that remove a key defender or open an entry file. The opening's attacking reputation is not sufficient compensation by itself.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

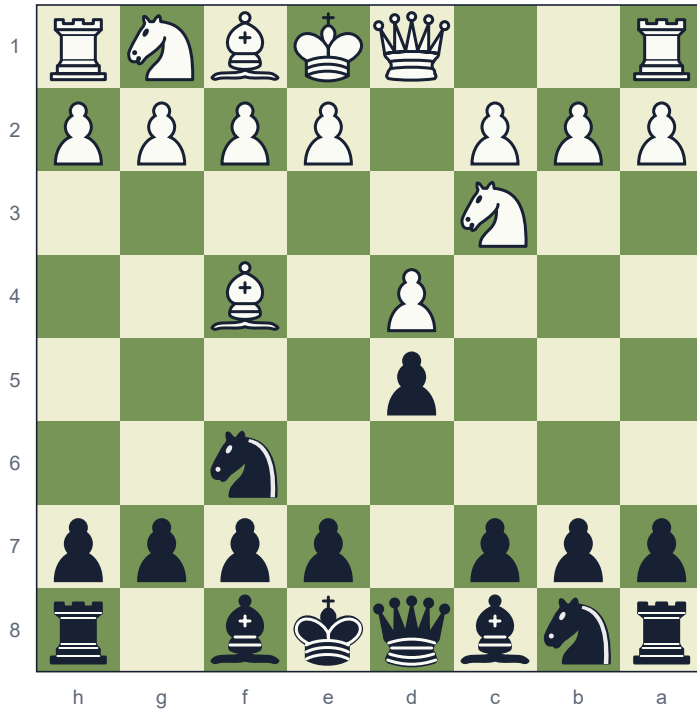
Count immediate forcing moves, the number of pieces that can join, the stability of your center, and White's chance to return material. If the attack depends on White ignoring a defense, reject the sacrifice.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Write a concrete continuation to a clear outcome or a stable position before committing material.

Defend a forcing threat before continuing the race

TACTICAL DECISION | 20-04



Black to move

THE IDEA

In the Jobava companion line, Nb5 would attack c7. ...a6 answers that specific threat before Black completes normal central development.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

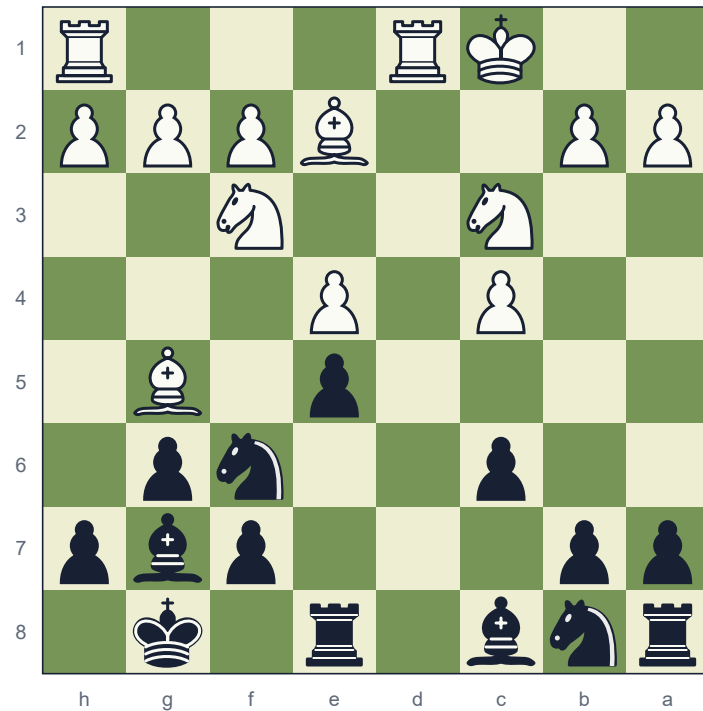
A defensive move is productive when it removes a forcing resource and lets your pieces develop smoothly. Compare the cost of one pawn move with the cost of an awkward forced response later.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Prophylaxis means identifying the opponent's actual resource, not making every possible precaution.

Queenless does not mean planless

ENDGAME TRANSITION | 06-01



White to move

THE IDEA

After the opening queen exchange, stop counting mating attackers and start counting active pieces, entry squares and pawn targets. Bring the king toward the center when checks and tactics permit.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

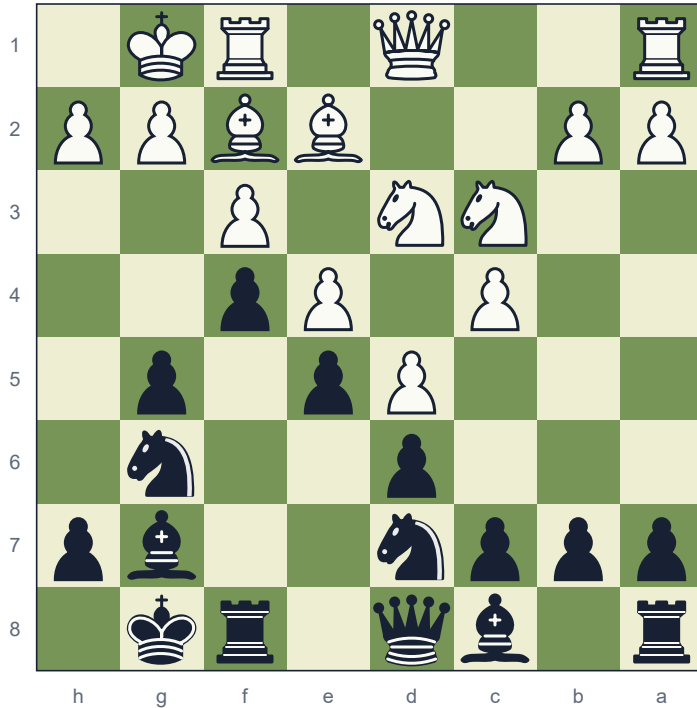
A rook trade is attractive if it leaves a favorable minor-piece ending or removes the opponent's only active piece. It is unattractive if it strands your bishop behind fixed pawns.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Before offering a trade, describe the position after both sides recapture. The remaining pieces decide the evaluation.

A bad bishop can still defend important squares

ENDGAME TRANSITION | 03-01



White to move

THE IDEA

The g7 bishop may appear restricted by e5 and d6, but it can restrain breaks and protect the king. Opening the center or changing the pawn chain may activate it later.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

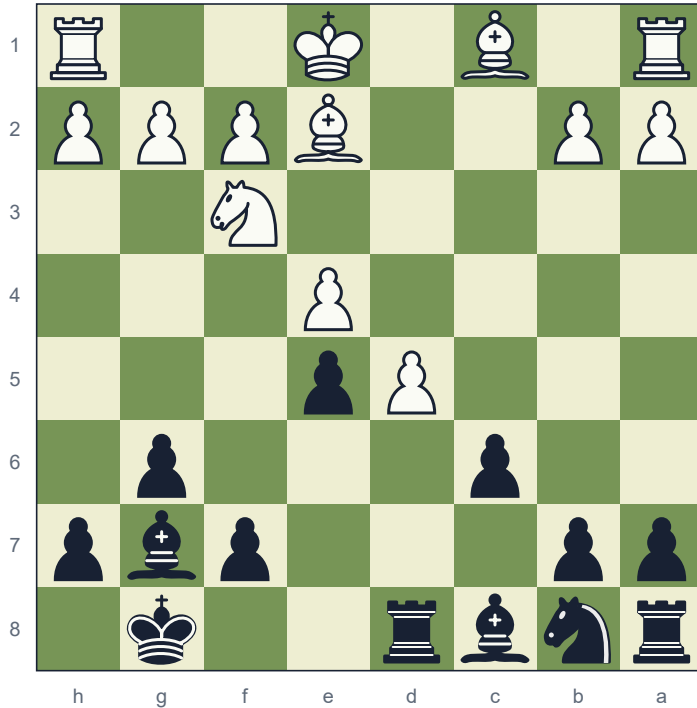
If queens come off, compare your bishop with White's knight outposts. Look for a pawn break that frees the bishop rather than exchanging automatically into a passive ending.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Do not label the bishop bad without naming which squares and pawn breaks it controls.

Use the king only when the position allows it

ENDGAME TRANSITION | 06-03



THE IDEA

An active king is valuable in reduced material, but rooks and minor pieces can still create mating nets or win pawns with checks. Centralization is a calculated route, not a one-move slogan.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

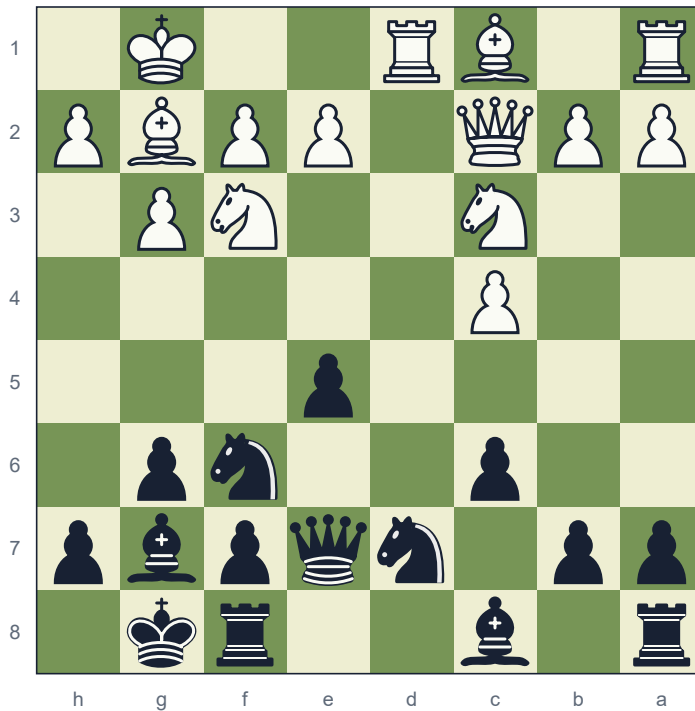
Find safe entry squares, count checks, and coordinate the king with a rook or minor piece. If the king cannot advance, improve a piece or create a pawn target first.

HABIT TO RETAIN

The opening plan is finished only when you have reassessed the new material balance.

Rook activity versus pawn protection

ENDGAME TRANSITION | 14-04



White to move

THE IDEA

Central exchanges may leave an open d-file and isolated targets. A rook tied to one pawn can become less useful than an active rook that creates counterplay elsewhere.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

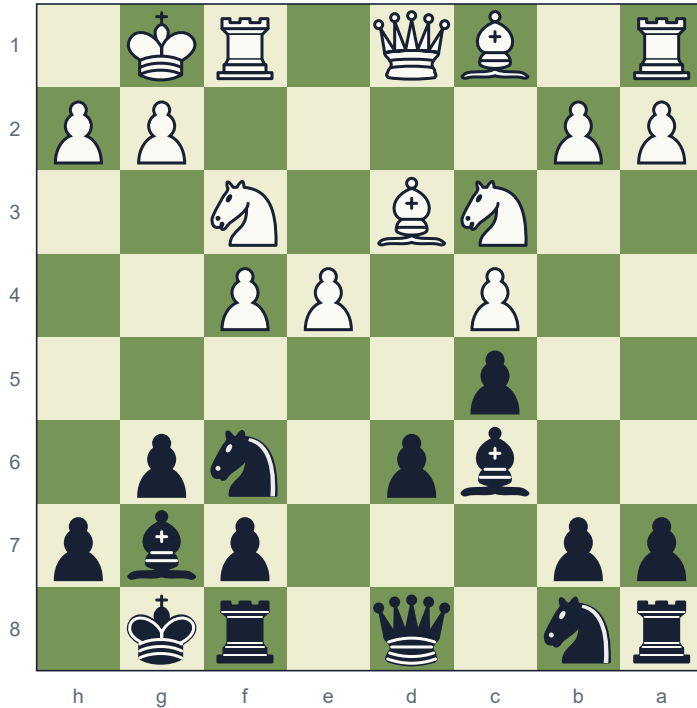
Compare active defense, a counterattack on another pawn, and a passive defense. Giving a pawn for activity needs a concrete line showing how the rook enters or how the pawn can be recovered.

HABIT TO RETAIN

In your review, identify the first moment a rook became passive and propose an active alternative.

Passed pawns and the choice of exchanges

ENDGAME TRANSITION | 11-04



White to move

THE IDEA

Benoni-style exchanges can create pawn majorities and potential passers. Count the pawn races only after checking blockades, king activity and whether a rook belongs behind a passer.

WORK THROUGH THE DECISION

Do not exchange into an ending merely because queens are dangerous. Compare the passer your opponent receives with the piece activity you retain.

HABIT TO RETAIN

Before a simplifying exchange, name the future passed pawn for both sides and the piece that can stop it.